

15 years ago, I went all in...



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“Yes, I didn’t build my first PC with my own bare hands, but by the mere fact that it was assembled by parts bought separately had a huge impact on me at the time.”

Nostalgia can be a nice little escape from the present reality. It’s a happy place where everything’s hunky dory, life becomes simpler, more exciting and innocent-seeming than everyone’s current predicament. Memories that are largely unaltered, yours alone for eternity. And I have a lot of fond memories from 15 years ago. It was a defining year of my life for more reasons than one. Technology, obviously, played a big part in it.

For it was in the summer of 2001, right after my SSC results came out and there was no doubt in my parents’ minds that I had spent myself completely in the great academic rat race, managing to not fail any subjects and actually doing really well in quite a few, that they decided to give in to my one and only request. I had to upgrade the home PC and get rid of the old abomination that sat in my father’s room, which even the friendly, neighbourhood electronics guy wouldn’t dare to touch anymore.

After half a decade spent playing with the rejected old PC from my father’s office, finally, I was going to get my first PC, and I had been given a budget to toe. The moment that I’d dreamt of every night for the past couple of years had finally arrived. So many thoughts raced through my head, but raising a mental middle finger in the faces of all my colony and school friends is the only spontaneous reaction I remember. I was laughing at their loathing and misery, literally feeling on top of the world.

As I dialled the number of a PC assembler from a now defunct shop on Mumbai’s Lamington Road, I knew what I had to do. You see, my best friend’s father had gifted him a HP Pavilion 8750 desktop PC (<http://digit.in/HP8750>) the previous year. While I enjoyed playing games on his PC and watching movies on CD drives, I knew deep down in my heart that my PC would have to be more powerful than his pre-configured, off-the-shelf HP machine. The stakes were high, but settling for an inferior machine was just not an option. I had to pull out all the stops. Which meant tears.

Crying was a price I was willing to pay to nudge my father into widening his budget by a smidge, as the PC assembler tasked with besting my friend’s PC configuration proved to be a shrewd businessman. Within a couple of days, he came bearing gifts.

I won’t ever forget that moment when I cold booted my very own PC to life for the *very first time* – how naive was I, right? I saw the boot screen fly by, the loading screen of Windows 98, and the system’s final sprint to the GUI desktop accompanied by beeping sounds and flashing LEDs. I was bewitched under a spell. I noticed that this wasn’t a barebones install of Windows – it came with bonus gifts like a ton of popular games pre-installed (pirated, of course). As I turned around to shake the “Good Guy PC assembler’s” hands, I think I may have let a solitary tear of joy run down my cheek. I was in heaven!

I didn’t sleep that night. There was so much to do on my new PC, so many games to play – Need For Speed II Special Edition!

The next day was a special one, too. As I called my best friend into my room, booting up my PC to show him the components inside, his jaw literally hit the floor. He was dumbstruck. My PC’s configuration (Intel Pentium 4 running at 1.3 GHz, 256MB of DDR SDRAM, RIVA TNT2 graphics with 32MB dedicated memory space, 40GB SATA hard drive, and a 3.5-inch floppy drive) was much better than his HP Pavilion 8750’s (Intel Celeron 633 MHz, 64MB of DDR SDRAM, onboard AGP graphics, 20GB SATA hard drive, and a 3.5-inch floppy drive). Now it was his time to cry and throw a fit at his dad. What fun!

Yes, I didn’t build my first PC with my own bare hands, but by the mere fact that it was assembled by parts bought separately had a huge impact on me at the time. To show off even more of my new love of computers, I realized something – I had to convince my father to get me a VSNL pack that would let HyperTerminal connect to the Internet.

Oh, and one other thing. Later that year was also the first time I ever picked up a Digit issue. The thought of playing the latest game demos bundled in the CD on my spanking new PC was just too hard to resist for my teenage self. And look where it led to! 

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